

Mid-Term Open Book Research Assignment

Course: Comparative World Religions – I
Topic 4: Religious Rituals of Semitic Religions

Student Name: Sudaish Kumar
University: Sukkur IBA University
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Submitted to Dr. Arbab Manzoor Ali

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3. Introduction

Ritual is often called the "grammar" of religion; the formal collection of movements which represents religious belief. Rituals are not simply abstract movements, but Divine commands that create, sustain and renew the covenant bond between God and humans, within the system of Semitic/Abrahamic faiths (Judaism, Christianity, and Islam) [1]. This study examines the ways in which these three related faiths employ physical practices, such as daily prayers, codes of diet, and once-in-a-lifetime pilgrimages, to create a sense of communal identity, demonstrate personal piety and guarantee spiritual sanctification. As descendants of the same father, they have different theological frameworks which guide their rituals. Rituals in Judaism serve as an important means of remembering the covenant and the history of the Israelites and are heavily based on daily rituals and the codes of law. Ruptures of rituals with emphasis on internal change and grace, became sacrament and community involvement (worship) in the body of Christ (Christianity and after Paul). In Islamic context, rituals have been described as 'Ibadah' which means 'worship and servitude' and is a way of life that constantly reminds the believer of God[2]. Even with these distinct forms however, it is possible to make a comparison of these traditions and discover that the rituals used in these traditions address the same basic human difficulty: sanctifying the profane world and remaining connected to the divine.

4. Objectives / Purpose of the Study

The purpose and goals of the study are clearly outlined and described. The main aim of this research is in-depth comparison of the ritualistic form of the Semitic religions. This study focuses on systematically exploring the role of rituals as a theological statement rather than a mere customs, in three faiths. This project aims to:

- Examine the theological importance and different practices of initiation in Judaism, Christianity and Islam.
- Discuss the ways in which "spatial" and "temporal" edges are sacred, e.g., sacred time, communal prayer.
- Discuss ways in which diet and purifications laws continue to be relevant 'living rituals' of daily life.

- Recognise pilgrimage as a physical expression of religious devotion and how it creates a sense of historical connection and links the wider world.

5. Research Questions

For the purposes of attaining the stated objectives this paper will respond to the following main research questions:

1. What are the meanings of initiation rituals (e.g. Brit Milah in Judaism, Baptism in Christianity and equivalent rites in Islam) and how do they help to construct early approaches to religion?
2. How much do restrictions of food and/or purification practices in these traditions have a connection with a similar understanding of spiritual discipline, self-restraint and the sanctification of the body?
3. What are the ways in which pilgrimage is a devotional act and simultaneously a chasm-bridging act, for the worldwide communities associated with these religions?

6. Hypothesis

This research suggests that although the outward expression of these rituals differs markedly between Judaism, Christianity and Islam with respect to how often they occur, their physical form and associated liturgical elements, the rites have the same basic teleological purpose. In all three Semitic religions rituals ground the human being in the Divine Will in a state of living that is always in a state of profaning. Finally, it is postulated that these similarities in ritualistic configuration reflect a common theology which functions as the main way these religions express its distinctive, yet interconnected covenant with God.

7. Discussion

The practices of the Semitic religions play an essential place because they are living systems in which faith is maintained and the nature of the community transformed. Dogmas and scriptures are the intellectual structure of religion, and dogmatic rituals are the physical structure of religion. Norman subsets the whole human endeavor of life starting from birth and personal needs, from the hours of the day to the days of the week, to the stages of adulthood and the

objectives of the life to come, forcing the bodies of the worshippers and their physical environment to embody broader spiritual truths.

7.1 Rituals of Initiation: Circumcision and Baptism

The ritual of initiation marked the transition from childhood to adulthood, and usually included circumcision and baptism. The initiation ritual is the 'threshold of faith' in the sense that it is an expression of the formal initiation into the religion and the covenant with God. In Judaism, the act of circumcision is considered the first procedure involved in males' initiation into the faith, known as the Brit Milah, or covenant of circumcision. As required by the Torah, it is conducted on the eighth day after a baby boy is born. Genesis 17:10-11 teaches us that God gave Abraham's descendants after him this new agreement, which is a visible and permanent sign of their membership of the 'Chosen People.' It is very communal and involves a Sandek (godfather), a Mohel (circumcisor) and there is a celebratory meal (Seudat Mitzvah), which shows five-fold that the child's covenant is not just with God, but with the Jewish people as well.

The idea of initiation, which was greatly coloured by the Pauline theological shift and the rejection of the Mosaic Law, was changed by Christianity as a whole. Based on St. Paul's statement in Romans 2:29 ('circumcision of the heart, by the Spirit, not by the written code'), Christianity eventually became a universal initiation rite, Baptism. Throughout Baptism, water creates an image: it is used to symbolize cleansing, destruction of the old, and creation of the new; Baptism is the washing away of original sin and the birth of the soul through Christ. It is a fundamentally egalitarian ritual, a sacramental passage into an open Church (Church of God is a diverse Church) where both men and women participate, and who moves away from the requirement of physical action for the participation of women (Brit Milah) which is purely physical. It is a fundamentally egalitarian ritual, it is not just physical ritual but, a sacramental entry into the Church, which is open to both males and females, who broke away from the requirement of physical activity for the participation of women (Brit Milah). Based on the denomination, Baptist may baptize infants (Pedobaptism) or only consenting adults (Believer's Baptism); what is common is that it is one's only point of entry into the Christian covenant.

Islam is a member of the Abrahamic faiths, but has some differences with the other Abrahamic faiths at least in its initial requirement for initiation. The first, fundamental requirement of the

Islamic faith is for a person to make a vocal, conscious statement. The first basic need for the Islamic faith is that the person makes a conscious and audible statement SHAHADAH 'There is no god but Allah, and Muhammad is His messenger'. Islam has, however, firm rites of "childhood initiation" which reflect the semitic heritage. Khitan is a rite practised by males, although it is not specifically prescribed in the Qur'an, and is linked to the man's Fitra (the natural human tendency towards purity), an important Sunnah and essential part of the rite of circumcision, and is important for the man. In addition, the Aqiqah ceremony (shaving of the head of the baby, the sacrifice of an animal and the giving of charitable gifts) is the communal celebration of the baby's birth and inclusion into the community of Muslims, known as the Ummah. Islam combines the spiritual act of direct profession with the physical act of integration, through these practices.

7.2 Sacred Time: Shabbat, Sunday Service, and Salat

Sanctification of time is an element that is common to all Semitic religions as a rite. Not only is the Divine eternal, but human life is also groupable into a rhythmic and ordered type of time to reflect or communicate "Eternity". The Shabbat (Sabbath) is in Jewish tradition, a weekly obligation to put aside that provides the foundation of Jewish life. Observing the Sabbath is embedded in the Ten Commandments: 'Remember the Sabbath day by keeping it holy' (Exodus 20:8)[6]. Judaism does not allow thirty-nine kinds of Melakhah (Creative Work) to be performed between Friday sunset and till sunset on Saturday. This rest is not simply resting; it is a conscious repetition of God's rest after six days of creation. Candlestick lighting by the matriarch of the family, the recital of the Kiddush over the wine, and the reading of the book of Torah in the synagogue all make that time a place of holiness. The Jewish people go to a different time through Shabbat, a time of holiness.

The theology of the Sabbath was embraced by Christianity but its focus was moved to Sunday, which in Christianity became a day to honor the Resurrection of Jesus Christ, which is the first day of the week. This 'Lord's Day' was the main focus of Christian time. The central act of worship of the day is the Eucharist (also called Holy Communion or the Lord's Supper). It is based on the Last Supper which is documented in the Gospels and features eating at the table made of bread and wine. Theologically, these are the body and blood of Christ (or "substance

and blood" in Catholic and Orthodox tradition), that is, Christ's flesh and blood. These are elements of Christ's body and blood (or, if you are Catholic or Orthodox, "substance and blood"). It is a great ritual of anamnesis – remembrance – in which the worshipper "eats and drinks" the sacrifice of Jesus as a concrete experience, in which he or she experiences the sacrifice essentially as part of the present gathering.

Islam divides the time around sacred differently: it is not allotted to one day as in Judaism or Christianity, but is kept sacred all throughout the day with the permeation of the sacred. Islamic sacred time is built upon the five required prayers or ritual actions (Salat) that are performed at fixed times as related to the position of the Sun (Fajr, Dhuhur, Asr, Maghrib, and Isha). This way, the Muslim is never given an opportunity to forget his affairs of the world even for a moment, so that he can remain focused on waswahq (remembrance of God)[8] all the time. Standing (Sajdu), bowing (Ruku) and prostrating (Sujud) serve as symbolic physical actions of giving up to the Divine. Besides, the week in Islam is dedicated to prayers for the gathering on a specific day which is Friday. Unlike Shabbat, Friday is not necessarily a day of a contradiction, it is a day where the Ummah is called for a gathering, a time that is set aside for them to listen to a Khutbah (sermon) and pray together in ranks, making everyone equal in the eyes of Allah SWT and instilling unity of devotion and unity of Islam.

7.3 Purification and Dietary Laws

The attitude to the Divine taken up in the Semitic traditions is that of ritual purity as a basic norm. Human body has to face the reality of life and be raised to the sacred presence. The idea of Taharah (ritual purity) is practiced in Judaism with a specific ritual bath, Mikvah: a separate ritual bath where living water is kept. For women who are polluted by having gone through menstruation, men who become unclean at certain times, and a convert to Judaism, they are obligated to immerse in the Mikvah. The other major system of laws that is equally vital, however, is the Jewish table; or dietary law, known as Kashrut. Parts of these laws are described in great detail in the Book of Leviticus and they state what is acceptable to eat (Kosher) and what is not (Trefah), which includes pork, shellfish, and mixing meat and dairy. In addition, slaughtering of the animals must be done in accordance with Shechita (humane slaughtering method) carried out by a trained professional. Each bite of food is watched by Kashrut, making

eating a continual act of obedience and consciousness[9].

Islam has a fairly similar concept of purity and food. According to Islamic law, state of Taharah is an absolute prerequisite to perform the Salat and interaction with the Qur'an. Muslim women and men must wash all the parts that they pray over in a method called Wudu before reciting their prayer. If there is a large amount of impurity, a full body ritual bath called Ghusl is performed. This physical washing is a parallel spiritual washing. There are also Islamic dietary laws. The Qur'an expressly states that swine meat, blood and meat that has gone bad (or dead animals) are Haram (unlawful) and cannot be consumed, thus defining the laws of Halal (permissible) and Haram (forbidden). Like all Jewish laws, Islamic slaughter (Dhabihah) involves invoking God's name, to reinforce the underlying theological principle that the slaughtering of animals for food must be done by His will. The commonality of ideals found between Islam and Judaism is highly significant in illustrating their strong dedication to incorporating religious awareness into the foundations of life.

The strict codes of physical purity and diet that formed the basis of Christianity have branched off from this tradition. Changing these words to imply that all food is clean comes from the Gospel of Mark (7:18-19) in which Jesus responds to doubts from His disciples by saying that what a person eats from the outside cannot pollute him. The change in the words to mean all food is clean is based on the Gospel according to Mark (7:18-19) in which Jesus addresses questions raised by some of His disciples by stating that whatever a person puts into his body from the outside cannot make him unclean. As a result, the dietary laws and physical purification and cleansing of food were largely disregarded as part of the mainstream Protestant belief making purity a personality trait of the heart. Yet the discipline of the body was still important, and was expressed in the rite of Fasting. For instance, during Lent, Christians may choose to give up certain foods, like meat, in order to develop and practice some sort of spiritual immersion into repentance and giving attention before the celebration of Easter. Although the form varies, the Christian use of fasting shows a united recognition that the physical body is a discipline that must be disciplined to grow spiritually.

7.4 Pilgrimage: The Journey to the Divine

The ritual of the pilgrimage is the most physical and also the most demanding for the Semitic religions. It's a ritual of space, it's a space that will take a believer from the everyday to the centre of the sacred. The Hajj to Makkah is the culminating expression of this for the Muslims. It is the fifth Commandment with the health and wealth, which is obligatory for all physically and financially fit Muslims to do at least once in their life. Hajj is an incredible emblem of ritualistic fellowship. Once pilgrims arrive within the boundaries of the sacred area, they put on ten pieces of white cloth (Ihram), which is a simple way to fashion similar garments. As pilgrims approach the precinct of the House, they put on ten pieces of white cloth (Ihram), the unwritten or unstitched type of white clothing. This ceremony removes any distinction of class, nation or prosperity, leaving a level sea of humanity in a planet of Godbeforehood. The elaborate rituals of the Hajj - the circumambulation of the Kaaba, the running between Safa and Marwa, the standing on plains of Arafat - are deep symbolic recreations of the ordeals of Abraham and Hagar, and express a powerful connection between the modern Muslim and his spiritual forebears.

Judaism historically focussed its most important rituals around the Temple mount in Jerusalem. This was stipulated by biblical law – the Shalosh Regalim - three festivals of affluence – Passover (Pesach), Shavuot (Feast of Weeks) and Sukkot (Feast of Tabernacles). In ancient times, the Israelites would travel from all around the land to Jerusalem to make offerings. The original version of these rituals were not possible when the 2nd Temple was destroyed in 70 CE, but the desire for Jerusalem is maintained by liturgy. Nowadays the practice of pilgrimage lives on in visits to the Western Wall (Kotel). It is the final vestige of the Temple Mount, and the holiest place to pray that can be accessed by the Jewish people. The journey to the wall, the stones they touch and prayer placed inside the crevices are a profound connection to the ancient Holy of Holies, and inherently very emotional and physical.

Pilgrimage, a different thing to Christians: not an obligatory commandment, it has been an important part of Christian piety since the fourth century. The birth, ministry and crucifixion of Jesus naturally attract Christian pilgrimages, which now focus on certain areas of the Holy Land: Bethlehem, the Church of the Holy Sepulchre, Jerusalem. The Via Dolorosa, or the Way of Suffering, is walked on by pilgrims in order to gain a deep sense of the suffering endured by

Jesus Christ in the gospel stories. In addition, the Christian concept of pilgrimage spread to other areas of the world, including Rome, Santiago de Compostela, and Lourdes, places of miracles or martyrdom. These trips are a sign of repentance, a quest for miraculous healing and a very special act of devotion – something inherent in the Catholic tradition – as well as in the Jewish and Islamic traditions.

8. Conclusion

A study of the religious rites found in the three Semitic religions presents an interesting dialectic: Although the most obvious means of distinguishability from the three religions is through their actions, their rites are also evidence of their shared theological genealogy. Throughout, these three religions turn to spatial movements, to structuring of time, to control of eating and drinking, and to the rites of initiation, to express their relation to the Divine. Essential to all these is the mutual image of providing the believer with a portion of that experience that is beyond the ordinary sphere of living: the Jews do this in the Shabbat, the Christians in the Eucharist, and the Muslims in the Salat which, although different in its mode of performance, all serve this function with respect to one another.

Furthermore, these ceremonies stand as a testament to the idea that one's faith is inextricably linked to one's obedience, restraint and physical activity, and thus cannot live in the purely intellectual realm. In the end, these rituals create the inextricable connections amongst people as well as a disciplining influence on the individual soul. The believers of the three Abrahamic religions share a common belief that by engaging in the ritual the human form itself and the world itself are united for a short while with the divine, and they realize that in doing so, they are making good on an ancient contract, which was made at the start of the three faiths' shared history.

9. Endnotes

[1] Peters, F.E., *The Children of Abraham: Judaism, Christianity, Islam* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2004), 85.

[2] Esposito, John L., *What Everyone Needs to Know About Islam* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2011), 32.

- [3] The Holy Bible, New International Version (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 2011), Genesis 17:10-11.
- [4] The Holy Bible, Romans 2:29.
- [5] Esposito, What Everyone Needs to Know, 41.
- [6] Neusner, Jacob, The Way of Torah: An Introduction to Judaism (Belmont: Wadsworth Publishing, 2003), 44.
- [7] Peters, The Children of Abraham, 102.
- [8] The Holy Qur'an, trans. Abdullah Yusuf Ali (Ware: Wordsworth Editions, 2000), 20:14.
- [9] Neusner, The Way of Torah, 65.
- [10] The Holy Qur'an, 5:3.
- [11] The Holy Bible, Mark 7:18-19.
- [12] Esposito, What Everyone Needs to Know, 45.
- [13] Peters, The Children of Abraham, 114.

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